

Treatise On Social Degeneracy

This treatise addresses a pressing sociological concern: the visible decline in the social fabric among today's youth, manifested most glaringly through the phenomenon commonly referred to as "brainrot" on social media.

The rise of fleeting, superficial trends mark the onset of a broader pattern of social degeneracy. These cultural symptoms are not isolated but symptomatic of deeper fractures in the values and behaviors shaping youth identity across Western societies, Eastern Europe, and other regions navigating the challenging shift from collectivism to individualism.

This treatise argues that targeted government intervention is not only justified but necessary to curb such degenerative tendencies before they solidify into irreversible social norms. While respecting individual liberty remains paramount, the unchecked surge of hyperindividualism has created conditions where community, shared values, and collective responsibility are eroded. The goal is to foster a balanced social order in which collectivism, often dismissed or ignored in today's individualistic world, is recognized and nurtured as a complement rather than an adversary to individuality.

The chapters that follow explore why youthful social degeneracy demands urgent attention, analyze its impact on societal cohesion, propose educational reforms designed to accelerate the social and moral maturation of Generation Z, and offer moral justifications for such interventions via deontological, utilitarian, and relativist ethics.

By intervening thoughtfully and decisively, society can reclaim a sense of collective purpose and resilience that sustains both the individual and the community in an increasingly fragmented world.

Miculpionier, 2025

Chapter 1: Introduction to Social Degeneracy and Its Impact on Youth

Definition and scope of social degeneracy

Social degeneracy refers to a decline in the moral, cultural, and social standards of a cohesive society. It manifests as behaviors, values, and cultural phenomena that erode communal bonds, promote superficiality, and encourage self-destructive or socially isolating tendencies, particularly among youth. This decline undermines the collective sense of responsibility and shared purpose necessary for social harmony and long-term stability.

It is important to distinguish social degeneracy from progressive or feminist social norms. Feminist and progressive values often emphasize equality, inclusion, and shared responsibility, thereby strengthening collectivism. Social degeneracy instead promotes fragmentation, shallow individualism, and cultural decay. The latter results in youth cultures that are characterized by transient fads, excessive self-centeredness, and a rejection of meaningful social roles or traditions.

The phenomenon of “brainrot” on social media, exemplified by the Tralalero Tralala trend in early 2025 and Skibidi Toilet in early 2023, illustrates the superficiality and loss of depth that define these new cultural currents.

Relationship between social degeneracy and neoliberalism

The relationship between social degeneracy and neoliberalism is complex and deeply intertwined. Neoliberalism remains a dominant force in shaping economic and social policies worldwide, largely due to its pervasive “There Is No Alternative” (TINA) doctrine. This dogma asserts that the current capitalist framework is the only viable way forward, leaving little room for alternatives or meaningful critiques.

Unlike libertarianism (which, despite advocating extreme individual freedom and minimal government, does not enforce a rigid

dogma and allows people to opt out of specific political communities like the microstate of Liberland) neoliberalism mandates conformity to market-driven principles as inevitable and non-negotiable.

At the same time, the rise of the far-right appears, at first glance, to challenge neoliberal dominance. Yet, historically, far-right regimes have often contributed to increased social degeneracy rather than its cure. Fascist governments notoriously suppressed leftist, communist, and collectivist movements. The brutality of such regimes, including the systematic elimination of political opponents during the Holocaust and Mussolini's violent repression, is an important reminder of how far-right authoritarianism corrodes social solidarity even while claiming to protect it.

Importantly, neoliberalism and the far-right are not wholly separate antagonists but often collaborators in practice. Neoliberals have been observed working alongside far-right actors on issues such as tightening borders and implementing austerity measures that disproportionately harm the poor and marginalized. For example, within the European Parliament, alliances form to push policies that reduce social protections under the guise of economic necessity, weakening collective welfare structures. This cooperation exacerbates social fragmentation and feeds into degenerative youth cultures by deepening socio-economic inequalities and undermining trust in both political institutions and community networks.

Thus, social degeneracy emerges not merely from one ideology or social trend but through the interplay of neoliberal economic policies, the authoritarian impulses of the far-right, and the increasing valorization of hyperindividualism. Each dimension influences and feeds off the others, creating a cultural environment where youth are left vulnerable to shallow, fragmented identities void of collective meaning or cohesion.

Overview of contemporary youth culture in transitional and Western societies

Transitional societies, with Eastern Europe as a primary example, offer a unique lens through which to observe contemporary youth culture. These societies, characterized by their shifts from post-communist collectivist frameworks toward more individualistic norms, often reveal the tensions and contradictions of this cultural transformation. For instance, even among Romania's top high schools such as Liceul Teoretic Ștefan Odobleja, where academic rigor is high, youth culture remains markedly superficial. This superficiality manifests in peer interactions focused on image, trends, and fleeting social validations rather than deeper intellectual engagement.

Superficial individualist cultures defined by aesthetics and banalities are, paradoxically, uniform at a global scale. The global spread of social media platforms, entertainment industries, and consumer culture creates homogenized youth identities that transcend national and cultural boundaries. Additionally, these cultures, despite their emphasis on personal freedom and uniqueness, share more similarities among each other than do the traditional collectivist cultures across Eastern Europe.

This trend toward superficial youth culture is not isolated to transitional societies. The United States and other Western societies exhibit these traits even more intensely, driven by consumerism and hyper-individualism that feeds into the rapid turnover of youth fads and cultural expressions.

Europe forms the primary focus of this treatise because the proposed solutions work best for developed societies and because it maintains a foundational collectivist orientation embedded in its social systems, historical legacies, and political institutions. The superficiality pervading youth culture threatens to destroy even these residual collectivist bonds, making it critical to address the cultural shift before even deeper social fractures emerge.

The Urgency for Government Intervention

Considering the issues outlined in the previous sections, one of the most effective solutions appears to be direct government intervention targeting social values. This intervention should take the form of mandatory educational curricula grounded in behavioral psychology and designed to promote collective responsibility and social maturity.

While economic measures play a crucial role in addressing broader systemic inequalities, social values require a distinct and deliberate approach. Young people cannot be left to their own devices amid the current cultural environment. Although adolescent minds are often not fully developed and may struggle with abstract or profound ethical concepts, the threat posed by unchecked social decay is far more urgent. This urgency justifies intervention even when it violates the natural (or mandated by traditional psychology) developmental timelines of young individuals.

Moreover, recent advances in neuroscience show the brain's remarkable neuroplasticity, the capacity to adapt, reorganize, and accelerate development in response to external stimuli and interventions. This means that well-designed educational programs can help youth mature socially and psychologically in ways previously considered unlikely within standard developmental windows. Far from stifling growth, decisive government intervention can catalyze the kind of accelerated maturation necessary to counteract degenerative trends in youth culture.

The specifics of such interventions and curricula will be explored at length in the next chapter.

Chapter 2: Government Intervention and Educational Curricula as a Response

Rationale for Rapid Maturation of Gen Z Through Education

The rapid maturation of Generation Z through targeted educational programs is an essential response to the challenges identified in Chapter 1. This section focuses on concrete justifications for such intervention, setting aside moral and philosophical arguments that will be discussed in Chapter 3. The concrete justifications include:

- **Counteracting Superficiality:** Current youth cultures prioritize transient trends and shallow interactions, which hinder the development of meaningful social bonds and critical thinking. Targeted education can deepen youths' engagement with constructive values.
- **Addressing Developmental Gaps:** Many adolescents today lack the guidance and environment necessary for healthy social and emotional growth. Structured curricula can fill these gaps by promoting maturity in areas that informal socialization doesn't.
- **Fostering Social Cohesion:** Strengthening collectivist values among youth helps rebuild community trust and cooperation, counterbalancing the fragmentation caused by hyperindividualism.
- **Supporting Marginalized Youth:** Youth who naturally embody more collectivist and less superficial values often feel ignored or disrespected in dominant cultural narratives. Extending their social and cultural vision through education honors and validates their perspectives.
- **Leveraging Neuroplasticity:** Scientific evidence shows that adolescent brains retain significant plasticity, allowing for accelerated social and emotional development when exposed to well-designed interventions.

- **Preventing Long-Term Social Decay:** Early intervention lowers the risk that superficial or degenerative cultural traits will calcify into entrenched social problems in adulthood.

Description of Proposed Educational Programs

In this section, the comprehensive set of educational programs advocated earlier is being proposed. These programs must focus on developing emotional, social, and behavioral competencies without succumbing to frameworks aligned with the Global Education Reform Movement (GERM), which has been critiqued for promoting standardized and market-driven education at the expense of deeper social development.

These programs must embrace experimentation and avant-garde methodologies to innovate and adapt to emerging youth challenges. They are divided into three categories based on their implementation and accessibility:

1. Mandatory By Government

These core programs must be implemented universally in all public schools. These programs will be free to ensure equal access and emphasize emotional and social development as equally important, sometimes more so, than intellectual growth. Examples of content and focus areas include:

- **Collective Responsibility and Civic Engagement:** Lessons on community roles, cooperation, and social duties illustrated through participatory projects and local engagement.
- **Behavioral Psychology Applied to Social Interaction:** Practical exercises in empathy, conflict resolution, and impulse control grounded in current psychological research.
- **Media Literacy and Critical Consumption:** Training students to critically analyze social media, advertising, and cultural trends to resist manipulative superficiality.

- **Emotional Regulation and Resilience:** Techniques to recognize and manage emotions, stress, and peer pressure effectively.
- **Historical and Cultural Education of Collectivism:** Exploration of local and European histories emphasizing collective achievements and solidarity.

2. Optional But Public-Only (Within Schools)

These programs provide deeper, more complex training that goes beyond foundational skills and caters to students ready for advanced development. They remain publicly funded and accessible only through school systems to ensure equitable opportunity while maintaining quality control. Examples of optional themes include:

- **Advanced Social Dynamics and Leadership:** Developing skills in group facilitation, ethical leadership, and social innovation.
- **Philosophy and Ethics for Youth:** Introducing moral reasoning frameworks to expand students' understanding of communal versus individual priorities.
- **Cultural Diversity and Inclusion:** Programs cultivating intercultural competence and appreciation of collective identities within pluralistic societies.

3. Optional But Private (Regulated Providers and Cooperatives)

These programs serve as extensions provided by regulated cooperative bodies or specialized public course providers. They offer innovative and experimental approaches not yet standardized, allowing for avant-garde exploration while maintaining oversight. Private schools, if they exist, would be required to adhere to the standards of the first two categories to prevent educational fragmentation. Examples include:

- **Experiential and Immersive Learning Programs:** Workshops, retreats, and community service projects fostering practical application of collectivist values.

- **Creative Arts and Collective Storytelling:** Using arts as a medium for expressing collective narratives and strengthening communal bonds.
- **Emerging Technologies in Social Development:** Programs exploring digital tools for cooperation, civic participation, and emotional awareness.

Managing Youth Opposition and Ethical Considerations

A significant portion of youth will likely resist these educational programs, viewing them as intrusive or restrictive to their personal freedom. This opposition is to be expected, given that adolescents often assert independence and reject authority, especially when confronted with structured interventions targeting their values and behaviors. Despite this anticipated dissent, the risk of allowing social degeneracy to persist unchecked is far greater and justifies moving forward decisively.

Managing youth opposition requires a combination of clear communication, transparency, and respectful engagement. It is vital to explain the purpose and benefits of the programs in a way that resonates with young people, emphasizing how these initiatives aim to empower them socially and emotionally rather than merely impose control. Involving youth voices in developing aspects of the curricula can also reduce resistance by fostering a sense of ownership.

Ethically, the intervention must balance respect for adolescent autonomy with the collective good. While some may argue that such mandatory programs infringe on personal freedoms, the developmental immaturity of many adolescents, combined with the demonstrated dangers of social decay, creates a moral imperative to act. The high neuroplasticity of the adolescent brain further supports intervention as a necessary measure to guide healthy maturation.

Moreover, safeguarding the programs from coercion or punitive excess is essential. The approach should be rooted in encouragement, positive reinforcement, and support, not punishment or shame.

Ethical implementation demands that the programs remain inclusive, non-discriminatory, and culturally sensitive, ensuring all youth benefit regardless of background.

Ultimately, the urgency of reversing degenerative youth culture outweighs youthful dissent. Carefully managing opposition with empathy and ethical rigor will ensure that these educational reforms can take root and produce lasting social benefits.

Historical Precedents of Successful Social Norm Interventions

Throughout history, various governments and societies have implemented programs aimed at shaping social norms and values among youth with notable success. These examples provide valuable lessons for designing contemporary interventions that foster collectivism and counteract degenerative cultural trends.

1. Post-World War II Civic Education in Western Europe

After the devastation of World War II, many Western European countries established compulsory civic education programs focused on rebuilding democratic institutions, promoting social cohesion, and instilling shared values of peace and solidarity. For example, West Germany introduced curricula emphasizing democratic participation, human rights, and collective responsibility. These programs played a critical role in reintegrating youth into a constructive social fabric and limiting the appeal of extremist ideologies for some time before neoliberalism became dominant.

2. Japan's Moral Education System

Since the early 20th century, Japan has included “dōtoku” (moral education) as a compulsory subject in schools that focuses on character development, social harmony, and respect for communal values. Following the disruptions of the post-war period, this system has been periodically updated to reflect contemporary challenges but continues to emphasize collective well-being over hyperindividualism. Japan's success in maintaining social order and

respect for societal norms among youth demonstrates the potential of structured, government-led moral education to shape social conduct positively, although there are some extremes in the Japanese collectivist approach, such as its apparent lack of emotion.

3. The Scandinavian Folk High School Movement

Emerging in the 19th century, the Scandinavian folk high school movement aimed to educate rural youth in the value of social responsibility outside formal academic settings. These schools contributed to the development of highly cohesive societies in Denmark, Sweden, and Norway. Their focus on experiential learning and community participation offers a model for integrating social values into education in ways that connect with youth experiences.

Chapter 3: Moral Justifications for Intervention: Deontological, Utilitarian, and Relativist Perspectives

Deontological Grounds for Duty-Bound Regulation of Youth Norms

Deontology emphasizes actions aligned with universal moral principles that are intrinsically right, regardless of their outcomes. In this framework, society, and by extension, its governing bodies, has an inherent obligation to protect the moral development and well-being of its younger members.

The duty to regulate youth norms arises because adolescents, due to their developmental stage, often lack the full capacity to make ethically sound decisions or foresee the long-term consequences of their actions. This developmental immaturity creates a moral responsibility for society to guide young people towards values and behaviors that uphold social order and respect for others.

Moreover, deontological ethics demands that individuals be treated as ends in themselves, not merely as means to social stability or economic productivity. Ensuring that youth are nurtured into morally responsible persons, capable of meaningful relationships and civic participation, is a duty that respects their dignity and potential.

Allowing the unchecked spread of social degeneracy, which fosters selfishness, superficiality, and disengagement, would constitute a failure to honor this duty.

The deontological approach thus supports prescriptive action: governments must enact policies and educational programs that uphold universal moral standards necessary for societal cohesion. This duty-bound regulation is not contingent on popularity or immediate consequences but is a principled imperative grounded in respect for human dignity and the future of the social collective.

Utilitarian Benefits of Collectivism-Oriented Education for Society

From a utilitarian standpoint, government intervention in youth education aimed at fostering collectivist values is justified because it maximizes overall societal well-being and happiness. Utilitarian ethics assess the morality of actions based on their consequences, specifically, the extent to which they promote the greatest good for the greatest number.

Collectivism-oriented education cultivates social cohesion, cooperation, and shared responsibility among young people, which produces widespread benefits for society. When youth learn to prioritize collective interests alongside personal ones, several positive outcomes emerge:

- **Reduction in Social Fragmentation:** Strengthening communal bonds decreases alienation, loneliness, and social conflicts, which are significant sources of suffering and social instability.
- **Enhanced Public Health and Safety:** Collectivist values encourage support networks and mutual care, reducing issues like mental health crises, substance abuse, and delinquency.
- **Economic Productivity:** Communities characterized by cooperation and trust create more stable environments for economic activity and innovation, benefiting society at large.

- **Sustainable Social Institutions:** Educating youth to engage responsibly with societal systems ensures their longevity and effective functioning, which safeguards future generations.
- **Prevention of Costly Social Decay:** Early intervention reduces the need for expensive social services and law enforcement responses to problems rooted in degenerative youth culture.

By focusing education on developing collectivist norms, governments enhance social utility, not just by improving individual lives, but by strengthening the structural foundations that sustain a flourishing society. The positive ripple effects justify intervention as a practical and ethically sound measure to increase overall happiness and reduce harm.

Relativist Acceptance in Enforcing Social Norms

Youth who adopt a morally relativist stance, rejecting fixed deontological rules or utilitarian calculations, may initially resist government intervention aimed at regulating social norms. Moral relativism holds that values and ethical principles are culturally and contextually dependent rather than universal.

Despite such resistance, intervention remains justifiable within a relativist framework when viewed through the lens of pragmatic philosophy, particularly that of John Dewey and his contemporaries. Dewey emphasized that moral reasoning is a process grounded in experience, social inquiry, and adaptation to concrete circumstances rather than adherence to absolute norms. From this standpoint, social norms and educational programs must be responsive to the cultural context and aimed at fostering communal well-being through experimentation and continuous adaptation.

Even relativist youth, while skeptical of fixed moral prescriptions, can recognize the practical need to maintain social order and support collective flourishing within their cultural environment. Intervention in this view is not an imposition of

universal truth but a negotiated effort to guide youth development in ways that make sense locally and improve social functioning.

It is important to set aside borderline pathological cases, such as youth with Borderline Personality Disorder (BPD), where moral reasoning may appear random or illogical, complicating universal justifications. The treatise should focus on the broader applicability of moral frameworks, including relativism, which is no less valid or logical in its domain than deontology or utilitarianism.

Thus, moral relativism provides a foundation for justifying youth norm interventions when they are culturally sensitive, flexible, and aimed at enhancing social cohesion in a given society.

Integrating All Three Frameworks to Support Policy

This treatise has drawn upon deontological, utilitarian, and relativist moral frameworks at various points to build an argument for government intervention in regulating youth social norms. Deontological ethics provides the foundational duty-bound imperative to protect and guide adolescent development as a moral obligation. Utilitarianism grounds this intervention in the practical benefits it brings to society at large, maximizing collective well-being and minimizing harm. Relativism adds necessary nuance by acknowledging cultural variability and emphasizing flexible, context-sensitive implementation.

Integrating these three perspectives creates a comprehensive ethical foundation that strengthens policy justification:

- **From deontology**, the policy gains firm normative authority, emphasizing that society must uphold duties to nurture youth maturity regardless of popular opposition or short-term outcomes.
- **From utilitarianism**, the policy aligns with pragmatic goals, ensuring that interventions deliver measurable improvements in social cohesion, safety, and collective happiness.

- **From relativism**, the policy remains capable of respecting diversity within societies and evolving with new social realities.

A policy framework anchored in all three allows for balanced decision-making that respects moral principles, embraces practical effectiveness, and remains attuned to local complexities. This multidimensional approach addresses potential criticisms from varied ideological perspectives, providing a unified but flexible basis for guiding youth education reforms.

Epilogue

This treatise has examined the urgent need for government intervention to confront social degeneracy among today's youth, a pervasive threat that erodes the shared values and collective bonds essential to societal well-being. Through careful analysis, it has shown how superficial youth cultures, fueled by hyperindividualism and intertwined with neoliberal and far-right influences, undermine social cohesion across Western and transitional societies.

Central to the argument is the call for targeted educational programs that accelerate the social and emotional maturation of Generation Z. These programs, grounded in behavioral psychology and inclusive of mandatory and optional tiers, aim to restore collectivist principles without diminishing individual dignity. Though youth opposition is expected, the moral and practical imperatives for intervention override such resistance.

The treatise also explored moral justifications from three distinct but complementary frameworks. Deontological ethics stresses society's duty to guide youth development; utilitarianism highlights the widespread benefits of strengthening collective responsibility; and relativism advocates culturally sensitive, adaptive approaches to education that respect social context.

Historical precedents demonstrate that such interventions can succeed when thoughtfully designed and sincerely implemented.

Integrating these ethical perspectives offers a comprehensive foundation for policymaking that balances principle, consequence, and cultural nuance.

Ultimately, reversing social degeneracy demands decisive, ethically grounded action. By investing in the collective future through education and cultural renewal, society can empower youth to become mature, responsible members of a cohesive community.

Addendum: The “Stoning Effect” and the Glacial Pace of Thought in Social Media-Immersed Youth

Much has been written in the treatise about superficial youth cultures and their role in accelerating social degeneracy. However, based on a new personal experience, it can be inferred that superficiality is not merely a matter of shallow values or fleeting trends, but it also manifests as a profound slowing of cognitive and social responsiveness, a phenomenon I now call the “stoning effect”.

During a brief moment on public transport, I addressed two teenagers, each engrossed in their smartphones, presumably engaged with TikTok or similar platforms. My questions were simple: Were they aware of the risks social media, especially TikTok, poses? How did they perceive the opportunity costs or alternative activities?

The responses were remarkable, not for their content, but for their sheer absence:

- The first replied with a hesitant “I am not sure about that”.
- The second’s only audible reply was a mumbled “yes, no”, delivered so quietly it barely registered.

Both individuals remained physically present yet emotionally and cognitively absent. Their engagement with the real world was low, or to put it in a more dramatic metaphor: they were inert, like stone, or perhaps like permafrost immune even to climate change.

This stoning effect appears not as a mere social awkwardness, but as an almost neurological phenomenon:

- **Glacial Pace:** The speed of recognition, processing, and reply was so slow that one could exaggerate and liken it to the motion of tectonic plates, not just glaciers.
- **Inertia:** Unlike natural slow thinkers who may eventually produce thoughtful replies, these teens' brains seemed to do a quick internal check, in a fraction of a second determining no reward, no effort, and then disengaged.
- **Reward System Hypothesis:** While we do not fully understand the biomechanics of reward (dopamine's impact on motivation, cue responsiveness, and habit formation is nonlinear and unpredictable), it seems plausible that social media has trained the brain so effectively to expect constant digital reward that any stimulus lacking such reward is ignored or shut down.

While two cases are not statistically significant, they align with wider trends, such as declining rates of face-to-face interaction, plummeting social engagement statistics, and self-reported alienation or numbness among youth immersed in algorithm-driven feeds. What appears as an anomaly is entirely possible, and even probable, in this new digital context.

Update as of 21 November 2025: For the purposes of this treatise, I posed the same question about the negative effects of TikTok and the opportunity costs of social media to two other teenagers. The first immediately put their phone down and acknowledged the negative impacts. The second, who was not engrossed in their smartphone, responded that they did not use TikTok and were unaware of its harmful effects. Both had sufficiently high reaction times to not qualify as being at a glacial pace, demonstrating that not all instances of engagement in such culture lead to the same inertia or social atrophy.

In conclusion, superficiality in youth culture is not just a matter of meme aesthetics or transient trends. It is measurable behavioral inertia. The treatise's warnings about social degeneracy thus require expanding to include this deeper level of social disengagement in some cases, where the brain's calculative apparatus, optimized for digital reward, actively suppresses real-world interaction.

I invite further observation and challenge: more systematic experiments, extended qualitative conversation attempts, and open critique of my assumptions.

Final Notice

This sociological treatise is explicitly subjective and intentionally crafted for political advocacy, not academic neutrality. Readers should be aware of several key characteristics:

- **No Citations:** The work does not provide formal references or quotations from established sources. Its arguments and claims are drawn directly from personal observation and experience.
- **Dominance of SaP Statements:** The vast majority of the treatise's propositions are universal affirmative (SaP) statements, asserting broad truths about youth, culture, social trends, and policy. These are used to give the argument prescriptive force and comprehensive scope.
- **Non-Neutral Perspective:** The treatise does not employ a detached, academic tone. It is advocacy-oriented, grounded in the lived perspective of the author.
- **Observational Basis:** Much of the analysis is rooted in personal observation. The insights and criticisms offered are not universal scientific truths, but as informed reflections of contemporary youth culture as seen by the author.

Readers should interpret these arguments accordingly: as contributions to ongoing debate, calls for action, and subjective critique, not as neutral, empirically validated social science.